Sikh seva and langar reading cards

White standard print

A practice with a reason

Sikhism is a religion also called Sikhi. Its followers are Sikhs. Equality and service are important in Sikh teaching. Seva means selfless service. It involves helping others without making a personal reward the aim. People can express a belief through a practice: something they do. We can ask what happens, which subject word fits and what value the action expresses. A description becomes clearer when it links the action and its reason.

Langar

A gurdwara is a Sikh place of worship. Langar is its free community kitchen and meal. Volunteers help prepare food, serve it and clean up. People of any religion or none are welcome. Sharing a meal together expresses equality. People are often seated together on the floor, with other seating for people who need it. Equality is about equal worth. It does not require every person to use the same kind of seat. We should avoid guessing what an individual needs.

Food and welcome

Langar food is vegetarian so that people from different backgrounds can share it. This does not mean every Sikh always eats a vegetarian diet. People can still have different food needs. A real meal needs trained adults, safe food handling and clear information about ingredients. This lesson is about describing a practice. We are not preparing food or acting out worship. Our imaginary planning cards help us think about welcome and care without pretending to run a real langar.

An invented planning question

In a made-up planning example, a volunteer is asked how to help everyone feel welcome at a community meal. One card says, 'Offer a place to every visitor.' Another says, 'Give the best place only to the richest visitor.' The first choice better reflects equality. A description might say that volunteers offer a free meal to all as an example of seva. Use the words because or shows to explain the link. Sikh people and communities are diverse. Our short account explains this practice and does not describe every part of every Sikh person's life.

Learn about these ideas without sharing your own belief. An adult can reread a short part.

Cards to discuss

A

A volunteer serves a free meal open to all.

B

A helper cleans up without seeking praise or payment.

C

Visitors of different religions and none can share the meal.

D

A visitor who needs a chair can use one.

E

Only rich visitors should receive a warm welcome.

F

Because langar is vegetarian, every Sikh must always be vegetarian.